

# Chapter 11: The Moment It Changes

Jenny almost convinced herself the words meant nothing.

People said things.

Emotions ran high.

Austin Blackwood was no exception.

That's what she told herself as she worked the next day.

And the day after that.

But something had shifted.

Subtle.

Uncomfortable.

Like a door slightly open that she couldn't close again.

"Table seven," Madam Chen called.

Jenny grabbed the tray.

"Got it."

But she already knew who was sitting there.

She didn't need to look.

Still... she did.

Austin.

Same seat.

Same posture.

Same calm expression.

But today, something was different.

He wasn't working.

No documents.

No phone.

Just sitting.

Waiting.

Jenny approached slowly.

"What now?" she asked.

Austin looked up.

"You're late."

"I'm on time."

"You're thirty seconds late."

Jenny blinked.

"Are you serious?"

"Yes."

A pause.

Then, unexpectedly, Jenny sighed.

"I hate you."

That made him stop.

Just for a second.

Then—

"No, you don't."

That irritated her more than she expected.

She placed the food down harder than necessary.

"Enjoy your meal."

She turned away immediately.

But Austin's voice stopped her.

"Jenny."

She froze.

Didn't turn.

"Yes?"

A pause.

"Sit."

Jenny turned slowly.

"What?"

"Sit."

"That's not part of my job."

"I know."

"Then no."

Austin leaned back slightly.

"I won't eat until you sit."

Jenny stared at him.

"...Are you blackmailing me with noodles?"

"I prefer persuasion."

"That's worse."

A few nearby customers were definitely watching now.

Jenny exhaled sharply and pulled out a chair.

"Thirty seconds."

She sat.

Arms crossed.

Eyes sharp.

"Talk."

Austin studied her for a moment.

Then said,

"You're avoiding me."

Jenny scoffed.

"I'm working."

"You're avoiding me."

"I see you every day."

"You don't look at me."

That landed.

Jenny went quiet for half a second.

Then shrugged.

"I have work."

"You always say that."

"It's true."

A pause.

Then Austin said quietly,

"I don't think you're afraid of me."

Jenny frowned.

"What?"

"I think you're afraid of what I make you feel."

Silence.

That was too accurate.

Too dangerous.

Jenny stood immediately.

"Okay. That's enough."

Austin didn't stop her.

But he added softly,

"You notice me too."

Jenny froze again.

For a second.

Just one.

Then she walked away faster than she meant to.

Behind her, Bao whispered,

"Oh my god..."

Jenny snapped, "Don't."

But Bao was already smiling.

And worse...

Jenny's heart was still beating too fast.

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The rest of the day felt wrong.

Jenny kept replaying his words.

*You're afraid of what I make you feel.*

Ridiculous.

Absolutely ridiculous.

She was not—

She stopped that thought immediately.

Because thinking about it made it worse.

By evening, the restaurant was quieter.

Jenny was wiping down tables when she saw him again.

Still there.

Still sitting.

Still waiting.

She walked over.

"You're still here?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

Austin looked up at her.

And this time, there was no teasing.

No arrogance.

Just honesty.

"Because I wanted to see you again before I left."

Jenny blinked.

"...Left?"

"Yes."

A pause.

"For how long?"

"Two weeks."

Jenny didn't know why that felt strange.

It shouldn't have mattered.

It didn't matter.

It shouldn't.

But it did.

"Business trip?" she asked.

"Yes."

Jenny nodded.

"Good."

But it came out wrong.

Even she heard it.

Austin noticed too.

He studied her face.

"You don't like that."

"I don't care."

"You're lying again."

Jenny exhaled sharply.

"I don't care where you go."

Silence.

Then Austin stood.

Not quickly.

Not dramatically.

Just calmly.

He adjusted his coat.

"I'll go then."

Jenny nodded too fast.

"Good."

But he didn't leave immediately.

Instead, he stepped closer.

Not too close.

But close enough.

His voice lowered.

"Jenny."

She didn't look away.

"Yes?"

A pause.

Then—

"Don't disappear while I'm gone."

That hit differently.

Too soft.

Too personal.

Jenny's voice came out quieter than she expected.

"I won't."



Austin studied her for one last moment.

Then nodded once.

And left.

The bell above the door rang softly behind him.

Jenny stood still.

Long after he was gone.

Bao leaned beside her.

"...You like him."

Jenny turned sharply.

"I do not."

Bao raised both hands.

"Okay, okay."

But he was smiling.

And Jenny hated that he might be right.

Because for the first time...

She wasn't sure if she was watching him leave.

Or waiting for him to come back.